



THE DANGER DIFFERENTIAL

As cars alternate between harvesting and deploying energy, the resulting **speed mismatches** are raising fresh safety concerns in Formula One.

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If the race in Shanghai was a glimpse of Kimi Antonelli's talent, the following Japanese Grand Prix was evidence that the prodigy will be a strong contender for the driver's championship in the 2026 F1 season.

With more than a big slice of luck — a cheap pit stop during a Safety Car period propelling him to the top of the timesheet — the Italian recovered from a poor getaway at the start to take his second consecutive victory.

The records keep tumbling for Antonelli. He is now the first teenager to lead the championship standings since Lewis Hamilton in 2007 and the first Italian driver to win back-to-back races since Alberto Ascari in 1953.

Teammate George Russell endured a frustrating day out in Suzuka, failing to finish on the podium for the first time this season. Despite the pace advantage of the Mercedes, the Briton failed to get past the Ferrari of third-placed Charles Leclerc in the dying laps of the race, conceding the championship lead to his junior teammate.

McLaren's Oscar Piastri, who had failed to start either of the first two races of the season, came home in second and could have even been on the top step if not for the untimely Safety Car.

The exciting three-team battle for the top six places is sure to

have brought entertainment, but the Japanese Grand Prix highlighted a systemic fault line within the 2026 regulations, one that could have worse consequences than what played out on track. On lap 22, Haas' Ollie Bearman was involved in a 50G crash (force fifty times the earth's gravitational pull) when his car slammed into the barriers at the Spoon Curve (Turn 13). The incident occurred when the young English driver had to veer out of the way of a slow-moving Franco Colapinto, causing him to dip a tyre into the grass and lose control of the car.

Why the Alpine was moving slowly opened a Pandora's box that F1 hoped to avoid with the new regulations. The crash was due to the high closing speed (the total speed at which two objects approach each other), which occurred due to Colapinto and Bearman's opposing strategies. While the Argentinian was